MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 1 — Unit 3: Drama

CHAUCER TO THE ELIZABETHAN AGE

Expanded exam notes · Simple explanations + developed discussion

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material (M21EG01DC). These are study aids, not the original textbook. Everyday comparisons are teaching examples. The original notes and full textbook units remain available in the subject folder.

The chapter in one sentence

English drama grew through religious performance, moral allegory, classical influence, and commercial theatre into complex tragedies and comedies.

Start with a picture

Imagine an idea moving from a church celebration to a town performance and then into a busy public theatre. Its audience grows, and writers find new ways to entertain and question people. This is a useful picture of development, although different dramatic traditions overlapped.

Learn it step by step

1. Mystery and miracle plays

Mystery plays commonly dramatise biblical stories, such as Creation or the life of Christ. **Miracle plays** are often associated with saints and miraculous events. Historical terminology can overlap.

These plays made religious stories visible to audiences, including people who could not read. Town guilds sometimes organised performances, and pageant wagons could bring scenes to different places.

2. Morality plays: ideas become characters

In a morality play, qualities such as Good Deeds, Knowledge, or Vice can walk onto the stage as people. This is **personification** and **allegory**. *Everyman*, for example, asks what matters when a person faces death.

Imagine a school play in which “Honesty” and “Greed” argue over a child’s decision. The characters represent competing values.

3. Interludes: short dramatic entertainment

Interludes are shorter plays associated with halls and courts, often mixing humour and moral concerns. They help us see the links between older moral entertainment and later secular drama.

4. Classical models and early English plays

Greek and Roman writing offered models for plot, rhetoric, comedy, and tragedy. Nicholas Udall's *Ralph Roister Doister* is an important early English comedy. Sackville and Norton's *Gorboduc* is an important early tragedy in blank verse.

5. Revenge tragedy: when justice fails

Seneca's tragedies influenced Renaissance drama through powerful speeches, ghosts, violence, and revenge. English writers adapted these elements. In Kyd's *The Spanish Tragedy*, a father's search for justice turns into destructive revenge.

Ask: "If the law fails, does personal revenge solve the problem or spread it?" That is more useful than remembering only the murders.

6. The University Wits and their dramatic world

Writers commonly discussed here include Marlowe, Greene, Peele, Lyly, Lodge, and Nashe; Kyd is often studied alongside them, although he is not known to have attended university. The label is a convenient grouping, not proof that every associated writer had the same education.

Marlowe gives his heroes enormous desires for knowledge, power, or achievement. His strong blank verse helps make those desires sound exciting and dangerous.

7. Jonson's comedy of humours

A **humour** in this context means a dominant disposition linked to an old theory of bodily fluids. A character may be ruled by jealousy, anger, or vanity. Comedy exposes the imbalance.

Imagine someone who sees every harmless whisper as evidence of a conspiracy. The repeated overreaction becomes funny and socially revealing.

8. Jacobean developments

Jacobean drama belongs to the reign of James I. Webster explores corruption and suffering in dark tragedies. Beaumont and Fletcher are associated with tragicomedy, which combines serious danger with comic or reconciliatory possibilities. Massinger and Dekker contribute further varieties of social and dramatic writing.

Remember these words

- **Drama:** a story presented through action and performance.
- **Tragedy:** drama involving grave conflict, suffering, and loss.
- **Comedy:** drama often exposing folly and moving towards resolution.
- **Tragicomedy:** drama combining elements of tragedy and comedy.
- **Blank verse:** unrhymed iambic pentameter.

Build an exam answer

Trace the development through religious plays → moral allegory → interludes and classical models → public theatre. Use examples, but explain that change was gradual and overlapping.

Quick check

1. Why can “Good Deeds” be a character? **Personification turns an abstract quality into a person.**
2. Does “comedy of humours” simply mean any funny play? **No; dominant dispositions organise its characters.**
3. Is Kyd’s university education established? **No; avoid assuming it from the grouping.**

Develop an exam answer

Practice question

Explain the development of English drama and the importance of its inherited traditions.

Expanded discussion

Early English dramatic traditions made religious and ethical questions visible through performance. Biblical episodes could be presented through mystery cycles, while morality plays personified qualities involved in human salvation. This method allowed abstract ideas to appear as actions, choices, and conflicts on stage. A struggle between good and evil could consequently become something an audience watched rather than only something it heard explained.

Later drama retained some of these methods while developing new subjects and techniques. Interludes joined moral concerns with shorter forms of entertainment, and classical models encouraged experiments in comedy, tragedy, and dramatic structure. The use of blank verse increased the expressive resources of serious drama. Writers such as Marlowe could give a central character’s ambition a persuasive grandeur, while Kyd could organise suffering and revenge into an intense sequence of theatrical events.

The development was not simply a movement from religion to complete secularism. Doctor Faustus still depends on a religious struggle for the soul, even as it presents a highly individual protagonist. Jonson’s comedy, in a different mode, turns attention towards recognisable social pretensions and dominant dispositions. Jacobean tragedy and tragicomedy further diversify the stage. English drama thus develops through the adaptation of earlier resources to changing audiences and new forms of social and psychological complexity.

Suggested answer structure

1. Religious performance
2. Morality and personification
3. Interludes and classical influence

4. Kyd and Marlowe
5. Jonson and later developments

Common mistakes to avoid

Do not treat mystery, miracle, and morality plays as interchangeable. Explain what the stage device actually allows an audience to understand.

Turn this into your own answer

Read the question again and choose only relevant sections. Make one clear point per paragraph, explain it, and connect it with a specific textual detail. Add accurate short quotations from the textbook where useful; the discussion above is paraphrase, not quoted text. Adjust length to the marks and time available.

Coverage review: extra exam details

Writer–work pairs for short answers

Sackville and Norton: Gorboduc. Udall: Ralph Roister Doister. Kyd: The Spanish Tragedy. Marlowe: Tamburlaine and Doctor Faustus. Lyly: courtly prose comedy, including Endymion. Greene: Friar Bacon and Friar Bungay. Peele: The Old Wives' Tale. Lodge: associated with A Looking Glass for London and England, written with Greene. Nashe: an experimental writer associated with the theatrical world; the grouping does not mean every writer contributed in the same way.

Beaumont and Fletcher need more than a passing mention

Their collaborative theatre combines elaborately managed plots, courtly settings, powerful passions, and expressive verse. Philaster provides an important example for tragicomedy: serious threats and emotional distress need not lead to the destruction expected in a straightforward tragedy. The Maid's Tragedy supplies a contrasting tragic example. Their dramatic career is explicitly an assignment topic in the textbook.

Later dramatists

Webster's The Duchess of Malfi and The White Devil explore power, corruption, and suffering. Massinger's A New Way to Pay Old Debts provides an example of social and economic conflict. Dekker's The Shoemaker's Holiday connects comedy with London social life. Link a writer's name to a technique or concern; do not offer an unsupported list.

Textbook assignment checklist

These are the unit's assignment prompts, included as a revision checklist, not as predictions of the exam. Longer answers still need evidence from the assigned texts.

1. Discuss the religious and moral elements found in Mystery and Miracle Plays.
2. Write an essay on University Wits by referring to their style and themes of plays.
3. Write a note on the dramatic career of John Fletcher and Francis Beaumont.
4. Analyse the nature of Ben Jonson's plays by referring to the Comedy of Humours.